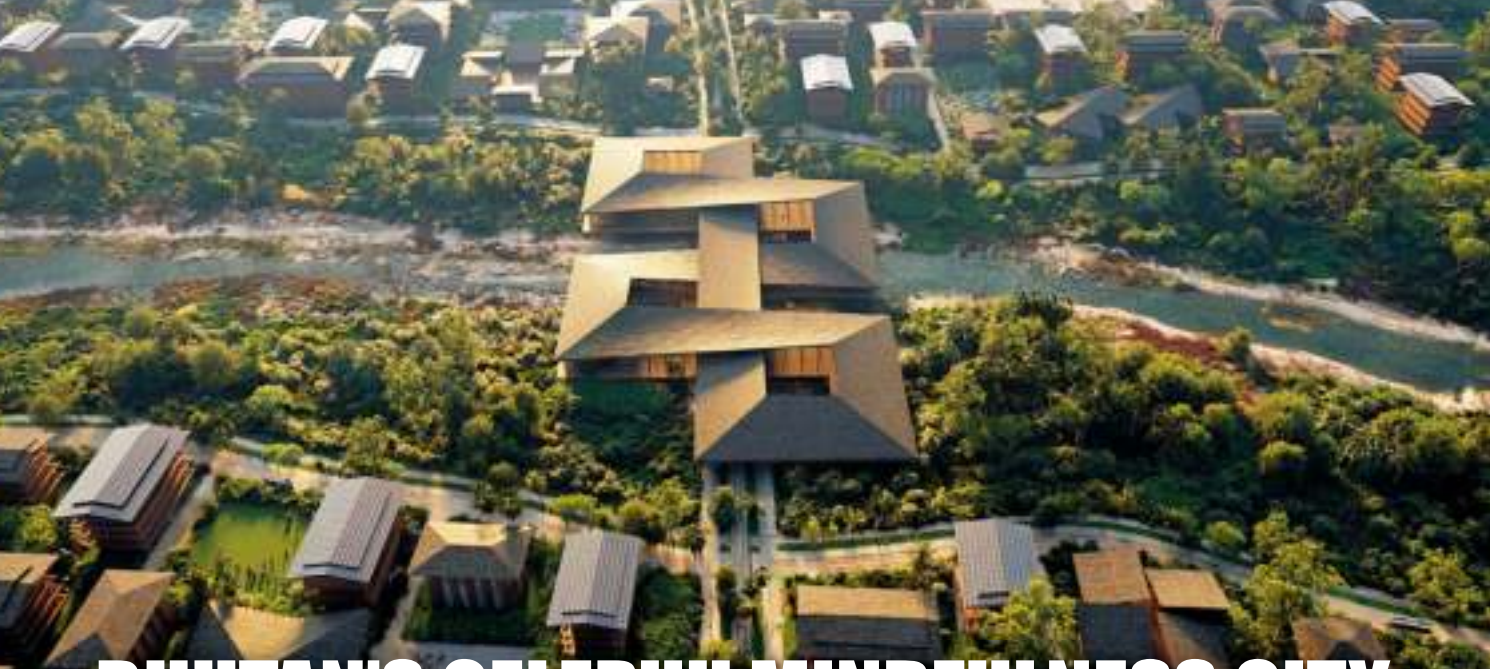


# BHUTAN'S GELEPHU MINDFULNESS CITY POWERS GROWTH WITH GOODNESS

**Buoyed by the success of Gross National Happiness Index, the 'hermit kingdom' is on a makeover mode. Amid an ambitious urban development project that integrates mindfulness, holistic living and sustainability with economic prosperity, the Himalayan nation is pulling out all stops to tap into its enormous hydropower potential to the tune of around 33,000 MW — its primary source of electricity and a major export commodity.**

The tiny Himalayan kingdom of Bhutan is on a road to nirvana.

Bhutan, known for its Gross National Happiness (GNH) index, which measures overall well-being, not just economic growth and a unique approach to development, is planning a "mindfulness city" that, once built, will cover some 2.5 per cent of the country — an area larger than the city state of Singapore and is being modelled on the lines of an autonomous region.

Preliminary plans reveal that the 1,000-square-kilometre (km) city will be built near the town of Gelephu, which is situated along Bhutan's southern border with Assam, India's most populous north-eastern state.

"Gelephu Mindfulness City" (GMC), as per the project's masterplan, aims to build an economic hub and gateway for tourists to the rest of the country.

His Majesty Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck is upbeat about the ambitious project, which has caught global attention.

He has said that Bhutan is "not trapped by legacy and can innovate swiftly to implement plans that other countries might hesitate to pursue."

> **"This partnership reflects our deep commitment to developing clean energy infrastructure that enhances regional energy security."**
>
> Naresh Telgu, COO (PSP & Hydro), AGEL

Though Gelephu is one of the key border crossings for Indian travellers, most international visitors fly into Paro International Airport, near Bhutan's largest city and capital, Thimphu, which is spread over 26 square km.

Construction of a new international airport and a dry port in the landlocked country has already started in Gelephu.

The Bhutan government is yet to announce any date of completion for the project.

Significantly, GMC appears to take a leaf out of Saudi Arabia's planned linear city, called The Line, which has created a global buzz about how modern cities look, function and serve the needs of residents.

> **"We look forward to taking this partnership ahead with Adani and learning from their huge successes across the globe."**
>
> Chhewang Rinzin, MD, DGPC

## Adani Group's maiden foray into Bhutan

As Bhutan shifts its development gear, His Majesty Jigme Khesar Namgyel has been pulling out all stops for a holistic makeover of what is often



(From left to right) Naresh Telgu, COO, PSP and Hydro, Adani Green Energy Limited (AGEL); Bhutanese PM Tshering Tobgay and DGPC's MD Chhewang Rinzin after signing of the MoU in Thimphu on May 8.